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The Publishing Dynamics: Why 90% of Publishers' Inventory is Hidden from Demand Partners

Everybody knows that the gap between publisher supply and demand-side platforms (DSPs) is growing wider, creating inefficiencies that directly impact publishers' revenue. This issue stems from the increasing complexity of our ecosystem, bid request duplications, and the overwhelming wasted traffic volume.



These dynamics are reshaping how publishers, supply-side platforms (SSPs), and DSPs interact, leaving significant portions of inventory under-monetized while pushing certain demand segments to their limits.

The Growing Gap in Revenue Distribution

Over the past three years, the difference in revenue between high-value and low-value inventory has grown significantly. Traditionally, inventory monetization followed a smoother curve, but recent trends show a stark contrast: the top-performing segments now yield up to 10 times more revenue than the lower-performing ones.

Nils Lind, CEO/Founder of [Assertive Yield](#) in [a panel discussion](#), mentioned that this disparity reflects a combination of factors. Safari's strict privacy measures have worsened targeting for a large group of users.

At the same time, advancements in targeting technology have improved outcomes for high-value segments, creating an uneven playing field. The result is a split ecosystem where some inventory performs exceptionally well while others struggle to find demand.

The Bidstream Bottleneck

The mechanics of the bidstream reveal another critical issue, Chris Kane, CEO/Founder of [Jounce Media](#), stated:



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There's roughly 90% filtering, so 9 out of every 10 times that the sell-side tries to run an auction, the DSP doesn't know that that auction exists.

Chris Kane
Jounce Media

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This disconnect has ripple effects. SSPs flood DSPs with duplicate auction requests to maximize visibility, but this overwhelms DSPs, leading to more filtering. For example, a single impression might be sent to a DSP through multiple SSPs or paths, creating redundant auctions. This duplication increases clutter and reduces the chances of an optimal match between supply and demand.

Challenges in Bid Stream Management

Managing traffic in this environment presents unique challenges for SSPs and publishers alike. On the SSP side, the inability to deduplicate requests in real-time creates inefficiencies. SSPs prioritize maximizing immediate revenue for publishers, often overlooking long-term consequences. For instance, sending the same impression multiple times might yield short-term gains. Still, it reduces the overall efficiency of the system, crowding out other inventory and inflating auction volumes unnecessarily.

Additionally, DSPs are increasingly selective about the auctions they process, implementing caps on queries per second (QPS) to manage costs. This selectivity, combined with the overwhelming volume of incoming traffic, forces SSPs to make tough decisions about which requests to forward. However, without effective deduplication, many of these forwarded requests are redundant, further straining the ecosystem.

There are also factors like:

1. **Auction Overload:** The sheer volume of bid requests overwhelms DSPs, leading to high rejection rates.
2. **Duplication Issues:** Without effective deduplication, SSPs send the same auction multiple times, adding to inefficiency.
3. **Short-Term Focus:** SSPs may prioritize immediate revenue, overlooking long-term consequences for inventory performance.
4. **Limited Transparency:** Publishers often lack visibility into how their inventory is managed downstream, making it harder to optimize strategies.

These issues create inefficiencies and revenue losses across the programmatic advertising ecosystem.

The Role of Traffic Shaping

The best traffic shaping solutions in the market are the ones from vendors that don't sell demand, avoiding any kind of bias, and the ones that offer AI-driven user profile matchmaking in real-time, enabling publishers to direct the most valuable traffic to each bidder, unlocking your inventory's full revenue potential. The most advanced machine learning algorithm can better shape the traffic for Higher ad fill rates and CPMs by reducing the throttling applied by SSPs, increasing the number of

But, traffic shaping itself needs to be well understood and approached in a meaningful way to achieve its full potential. Benjamin Hansz, Vice President of Strategy for Simpliix's [Rivr](#), in an [interview with AdMonsters](#), said:

"Waste" or unanswered bid requests currently account for an obscene portion of most bid streams. Over 90%. This "waste" places strain on SSP performance and has monetary implications—including server resource costs—that hurt a company's bottom line. Traffic shaping tools cut this waste drastically and have a positive impact on the entire equation"

In this discussion ["Publishing Dynamics: Publishers' Supply is Hidden from Demand Partners"](#) with Chris Kane from Jounce Media, and Rob Beeler, from Beele.tech, Nils Lind, CEO/Founder of [Assertive Yield](#), stated that it's highly beneficial and efficient if publishers employ Traffic Shaping on their end

"Effective traffic shaping lets publishers prioritize their most valuable impressions, ensuring they're routed to the right buyers at the right time. By cutting down on duplication and managing the bidstream better, publishers can make sure DSPs don't overlook high-value inventory while still ensuring broad visibility for their mid- and lower-tier segments."

Episode 1 is LIVE And Available Now! Watch the [complete discussion here](#):



Key strategies for Traffic Shaping include:

1. **Prioritizing the Right Impressions:** Traffic shaping involves identifying high-value impressions and routing them to the most competitive channels. This ensures that premium inventory is

2. Smart Filtering: Advanced algorithms can reduce auction duplication, ensuring each bid request sent to DSPs is unique and relevant.
3. Dynamic Auction Management: AI-powered systems adjust auction settings in real-time, considering factors like demand availability, user behavior, and time of day to maximize revenue.
4. Balancing Supply and Demand: By understanding DSPs' query-per-second (QPS) limits, SSPs can balance the volume of bid requests to avoid overwhelming DSPs while ensuring diverse inventory is represented.
5. Improving Transparency: Traffic shaping tools can provide publishers with insights into how their inventory is being filtered and matched, enabling them to make informed decisions.

Incorporating these methods reduces inefficiencies, strengthens buyer relationships, and ensures underutilized inventory gets better exposure.

Watch this exclusive four-episode series [DPO Master: Traffic Shaping for Revenue Growth](#) with industry experts Chris Kane, Nils Lind, and Rob Beeler on how to tackle the biggest challenges and opportunities for Digital Publishers, SSPs, and DSPs. And discover how to unlock unseen inventory, and master advanced techniques like traffic shaping and dynamic flooring, to drive growth and innovation in the year ahead.

PUBLISHERS **DPO** mastery

Traffic Shaping for Revenue Growth

Shape Your Traffic, Shape Your Revenue!

Chris Kane
Founder
Jounce Media

Nils Lind
Founder & CEO
Assertive Yield

Rob Beeler
Founder & CEO
Beeler.Tech

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Collaboration Is Key

Addressing these issues requires collaboration across the entire supply chain.

Publishers are [adopting tools](#) that give them more control and insight into their inventory's visibility through the programmatic ecosystem. Traffic shaping has become an essential tool not only to increase auction quality but also to enhance SSPs relationships.

SSPs in turn, are also investing in technologies that enhance [QPS Optimization](#) and improve the bid rate seen by the external bidders, selecting monetizable requests to better utilize the QPS limits, improving ROI for all participants.

DSPs could implement [DSP Request Deduplication](#) tools to optimize bidding costs, reduce carbon footprint, and improve Marketer ROI by accessing unique inventory.

Industry Collaboration is crucial. When AdTech, Publishers, SSPs, and DSPs are aligned into the relevance of a more transparent supply & demand path, we'll be able to have a more sustainable and efficient ecosystem.

To learn more about these dynamics and how you can navigate these challenges as a publisher, watch the [DPO Mastery: Traffic Shaping for Revenue Growth](#) series featuring 3 top industry leaders.

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Nils Lind



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Traffic Shaping for Pubs

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